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ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Effects of entertainment media framing on support for gay rights in China: Mechanisms of attribution and value framing

Lihong Zhang^a and Young Min^{b*}

^a*Graduate School of Journalism & Mass Communication, Korea University, Seoul, Republic of Korea;* ^b*School of Media & Communication, Korea University, Seoul, Republic of Korea*

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This study investigates the framing effects of gay-themed entertainment media in China. Specifically, the study explores the mechanisms underlying attribution framing and value framing, through two separate experiments. The results of the first experiment indicate that exposure to attribution frames had considerable influence on the participants' perceptions of the controllability of homosexuality and their emotional responses. In addition, fictional entertainment media's framing of the origin of homosexuality indirectly influenced the participants' opinion through anger. Those participants exposed to a program homosexuality as a type of 'controllable' sexuality were likely to express anger and thus were not likely to support gay rights. The results of the second experiment indicate that the core values reflected in a gay-themed program affected the participants' opinions by changing their perception of the importance of value-related beliefs. Those participants exposed to a frame reflecting family values were likely to consider beliefs about family values to be important, which facilitated their support for gay people's personal dignity and equal rights to jobs, housing, and freedom of expression, among others.

Keywords: entertainment media; homosexuality; attribution framing; value framing; support for gay rights

Introduction

Fictional entertainment media such as movies and television dramas have considerable influence on the formation and adjustment of the audience's beliefs and opinions about controversial social issues (for a review, see Green, Strange, & Brock, 2002). Audiences exposed to an entertainment narrative tend to interpret issues or characters in a way that is consistent with the ideas implicitly advocated in the narrative (Green & Brock, 2000; Slater, Rouner, & Long, 2006; Strange & Leung, 1999). Nabi (2002a) found that exposure to a narrative of various issues surrounding juvenile crime and domestic terrorism has a significant positive effect on the audience's acceptance of proposed legislative initiatives for addressing these issues. Holbert, Pillion, et al. (2003) found that the positive image of the American president shown in the television drama *The West Wing* led the viewers to favorably evaluate the office in general.

Entertainment or narrative effects have attracted considerable scholarly attention in recent years (Dahlstrom, 2010; Kim & Vishak, 2008; Morgan, Movius, & Cody,

*Corresponding author. Email: ymin@korea.ac.kr

2009; Slater et al., 2006). According to Green and Brock (2000), entertainment media can draw audiences into the narrative and make them accept the beliefs implicitly advocated in the narrative. Cin, Zanna, and Fong (2004, p. 177) pointed out that entertainment programs can change the audience's strongly held initial attitudes either 'by reducing the amount and effectiveness of counter-arguing or logical consideration of the message' or by strengthening their identification with the story's characters. Slater et al. (2006) explored the effects of television dramas on the audience's support for same-sex marriage and capital punishment and found significant effects only for the latter, suggesting that entertainment media can be persuasive when the narrative suppresses the audience's ideological predispositions.

These effects of entertainment media can be explained in terms of framing theory. Originating from sociology, framing research has examined how various media construct the meaning of social issues by selecting, excluding, punctuating, and elaborating on particular aspects of a given issue, event, or condition (Entman, 1993; Gitlin, 1980). A media frame reflects a constructed package of meanings concerning a particular issue (Gamson & Modigliani, 1989) and can influence audiences' interpretation of the issue and thus their opinions (Brewer, 2003; Brewer & Gross, 2005; de Vreese, Boomgaarden, & Semetko, 2011; Iyengar, 1991; Nelson, Clawson, & Oxley, 1997; Simon & Jerit, 2007). However, despite the growing interest in framing research in recent decades, it remains conceptually unclear what frames or framing effects really refer to (Borah, 2011; Entman, 1993; Nelson, Oxley, & Clawson, 1997). Some studies have explored media frames mainly as a mode of attribution (Iyengar, 1991; Snow & Benford, 1992), whereas others have focused on the association between an issue (or any object of the media frame) and core values (Brewer, 2001, 2002, 2003; Brewer & Gross, 2005; Shah, Domke, & Wackman, 1996). Symbolic devices such as metaphors, exemplars, catchphrases, visual images, and word choices have also been considered as important elements of media frames (Gamson & Modigliani, 1989). In sum, media frames have a complicated structure consisting of various elements such as core values, attribution patterns, and symbolic devices and their interrelationships. Consequently, media frames may influence audiences' causal attribution and value-related beliefs, among others. A number of studies have also considered issue-relevant opinions as the dependent variable to examine the media's framing effects (Chong & Druckman, 2007; de Vreese et al., 2011).

Although numerous studies have focused on the framing effects of news media, few have examined the framing effects of fictional entertainment media featuring controversial social issues and the mechanisms underlying those effects. Mulligan and Habel (2011) coined the term 'fictional framing' and argued that very few studies have tested such framing effects. To fill this gap in the literature, the present study explores the framing effects of gay-themed entertainment programs on the audience's opinions on homosexuality by focusing on causal attributions and core values as the key elements of media frames. That is, this study considers attribution framing and value framing as the primary mechanisms of media framing. In addition, the study contributes to the literature by exploring the issue of homosexuality in the context of a relatively conservative culture: China. As of 2010, China had approximately 30 million homosexuals (The Economist, May 18, 2010).¹ While homosexuality has become a subject of intense debate in public discourse, movies about homosexuality and related identity issues have recently claimed most of the top prizes in various movie festivals in China (Dong, 2009). This indicates that fictional entertainment

media may have considerable influence on Chinese audiences' opinions about homosexuals by reducing cultural resistance and/or ideological counterarguments. In this regard, the present study examines the framing effects of gay-themed movies and television dramas on Chinese audiences' support for homosexuality and (more importantly) clarifies the mechanisms mediating these effects.

Media framing of homosexuality

As in the framing of other social and political issues, the media adopt various frames to portray homosexuality, focusing mainly on attribution patterns and core values. Several studies have suggested that certain attributions or core values may increase the audience's support for homosexuals or gay-rights policies, whereas other attributions or values may induce the opposite effect (Brewer, 2002, 2003; Harder-Markel & Joslyn, 2008).

In terms of causal attributions, media discourse has frequently depicted homosexuality either as a hereditary trait that cannot be changed by any subjective initiatives or as a matter of an individual's personal choice of his or her sexual identity that may change over the course of his or her life (Wilcox, 2003). In other words, the causes of homosexuality can be framed either as uncontrollable (i.e., hereditary trait) or as controllable (i.e., personal choice). Moral judgments, affective emotions, and behavioral tendencies regarding homosexuality may vary according to the causal attribution of homosexuality, which entails a social stigma (Weiner, 2006).

In essence, homosexuality is a value-laden issue. In this regard, Brewer (2003) provided a particularly insightful analysis by exploring the value frames associated with the issue of gay rights. According to Brewer, the American media have generally considered two types of value frames with respect to same-sex relationships: anti-gay morality frames emphasizing traditional moral values and pro-gay equality frames highlighting equal rights as US citizens. In addition, Hull (2001) identified tolerance frames underscoring diversity and mutual respect as another mainstream media frame facilitating the audience's support for gay rights.

In recent years, some entertainment programs have positively contextualized same-sex relationships in terms of traditional values. For example, the movie *Beautiful Thing* associates homosexuality with family values. When the main character, a gay protagonist, finds out that her son is also gay, she is angry about her son's dishonesty, not about his homosexuality. She, as a parent, reacts positively to her son's disclosure of his sexual identity (Padva, 2004), which clearly links homosexuality to the family values of honesty and unconditional love. However, as Brewer (2003) pointed out, traditional family values are often juxtaposed with homosexuality. This can be observed in many movies, including *Brokeback Mountain*, *Feeding by Night*, and *The River*. For instance, as Ennis and Jack, the main male characters in *Brokeback Mountain*, become romantically involved, they are increasingly negligent of their families and finally break away from their family relationships. In the Chinese movie *Feeding by Night*, the main character's declaration of his homosexuality destroys his family's reputation in the old Chinese community and pushes him into exile abroad for the rest of his life, devastating his parents.

The above discussion indicates that the media framing of gay issues may vary according to the attribution of the cause of homosexuality and the underlying values.

In this regard, this study examines the effects of homosexuality-related frames on the audience's opinions on gay-related issues by focusing on the effects of causal attributions and core values reflected in the entertainment narrative.

Mechanisms of attribution framing: Attributions, emotions, and opinions

As discussed earlier, this study considers causal attributions as one of the key components of media frames, which can influence the audience's interpretation of who or what is responsible for a given problem. Iyengar (1991, 1996) demonstrated that news media tend to frame audiences' judgments about the responsibility for social problems such as poverty, unemployment, crime, and racial discrimination, among others. For instance, episodic news frames attribute the responsibility for a social problem to individual or situational factors, whereas thematic ones attribute it to societal or structural ones. Similarly, Haider-Markel and Joslyn (2001) pointed out that media frames have considerable influence on the causal attribution of blame for tragic events. As such, the attribution of some causal or treatment responsibility represents an essential function of media frames. This is where the notion of framing meets that of attribution, and this study specifically conceptualizes it as attribution framing. Although previous studies have focused mainly on attribution framing in news reports, Rhode and Hamilton (2006) argued that the consumption of fictional dramas can also stimulate attributional thinking. They suggested that 'novels and movies are enjoyable to the extent that they engage the reader in process of attributional thinking' (p. 129) and that a drama's characterization and perspective can help the audience to draw causal inferences.

Based on the above discussion, the present study examines the mechanism underlying fictional entertainment media's attribution framing and its effects.

According to attribution theory, individuals attempt to determine whether an individual involved in a negative social event is responsible for some unethical action by drawing inferences about his or her motivation and the causes of the event (Weiner, 2006). Weiner (1995) identified three dimensions of causal attribution: the locus of causality (internal or external to the individual involved), stability (whether the cause is consistent over time), and controllability (controllable or uncontrollable by the involved party). Internal causes are often considered uncontrollable, whereas external causes, uncontrollable. However, this is not always the case. For instance, an internal cause such as an individual's personal aptitude is uncontrollable, and therefore it is difficult to blame someone for his or her low aptitude. On the other hand, certain external causes are controllable by the individuals involved, and therefore the moral blame can be laid on those individuals. In this regard, Weiner (2006) pointed out that the dimension of controllability is 'more important in social contexts' than the locus of causality 'because it relates directly to moral judgments' (p. 10).

An individual's causal attribution of a social problem, particularly a judgment about the controllability of the cause, may evoke certain emotions (Weiner, 1995, 2006). According to Lazarus (1991), discrete emotions such as anger and sympathy are generated based on an individual's subjective appraisal of a given situation, and his or her attribution of blame or responsibility may be an important part of this cognitive appraisal. For instance, anger can be aroused when an individual believes that a controllable cause was behind a negative outcome and

thus that the outcome could have been avoided or replaced with a better outcome. However, such an emotion can dissipate if the negative outcome is perceived as something uncontrollable by the responsible party. Emotions such as pity and compassion can be evoked when it is believed that someone suffers some misfortune as a result of an uncontrollable external or internal cause (Weiner, 1995). Weiner (1985, 1995) proposed that emotions triggered by causal attributions can motivate individuals to take social action. For instance, anger can lead individuals to punish the person judged as responsible for a negative outcome, whereas sympathy can foster their willingness to help those who are suffering from some misfortune. Similarly, emotions can influence subsequent opinions. Nabi (2002a) showed that anger toward juvenile criminals or domestic terrorists increases individuals' acceptance of legislative initiatives for addressing those problems. Previous studies have produced mixed results for the effects of sympathy on attitudes, but sympathy generally 'provides important sources of social support' for minority groups (Nabi, 2002b, p. 298).

Weiner (2006) demonstrated the validity of attribution theory in the context of a social stigma by analyzing the mechanism through which a judgment about the controllability of a particular cause of a stigmatizing event leads to particular emotions and action tendencies. In the case of a disease-related stigma, individuals tend to avoid laying the blame on patients with hereditary diseases (uncontrollable) and thus are likely to feel pity for them, whereas they tend to blame patients with acquired diseases (controllable) and thus are likely to feel anger. Similarly, this mechanism can explain other stigma-related issues. In sum, individuals' opinions on various issues surrounding a stigma can be influenced by their judgment on the controllability of the origin of the stigma. If the origin is perceived as behavioral in nature (i.e., something controllable and chosen by the responsible party), then individuals may feel negative emotions such as anger and thus may show hostile action tendencies and attitudes toward the party. By contrast, if the origin is judged as dispositional or situational in nature (i.e., something uncontrollable by the responsible party), then individuals tend to feel sympathy and thus form favorable opinions.

As an issue reflecting a serious social stigma, homosexuality has been examined from the perspective of attribution theory (Harder-Markel & Joslyn, 2008; Sakalli, 2002; Tygart, 2000; Wood & Bartkowski, 2004). Previous studies have typically employed the survey method to demonstrate a significant positive relationship between 'controllable' attributions and a lack of support for same-sex relationships (Sakalli, 2002; Tygart, 2000; Wood & Bartkowski, 2004). However, most studies have overlooked the role of emotions, which can mediate beliefs about the controllability of homosexuality and thus opinions on homosexuality-related issues. To address this gap in the literature, the present study suggests the 'attribution-emotion-opinion' path as a possible mechanism underlying the framing effects of fictional entertainment media.

As discussed thus far, this study considers controllability as the most essential component of attribution framing. The way in which the controllability of homosexuality is framed by entertainment media may influence audiences' perception of this controllability, which in turn may influence their emotional responses to gay people. Such emotions can ultimately influence their opinions on same-sex relationships and gay rights. In this regard, we propose the following hypotheses,

which together address the indirect effects of attribution framing on audiences' opinions through perceived controllability and emotions:

Hypothesis 1 (H1): Exposure to an attribution frame in a gay-themed entertainment program influences the audience's interpretation of the causes of homosexuality. Specifically, audiences exposed to a media frame portraying homosexuality as something controllable are more likely to perceive the controllability of homosexuality than those exposed to a media frame presenting homosexuality as something uncontrollable.

Hypothesis 2 (H2): Audiences' perception of the controllability of homosexuality influences their emotional responses to homosexuals.

H2a: The perceived controllability of homosexuality is positively related to anger toward homosexuals.

H2b: The perceived controllability of homosexuality is negatively related to sympathy for homosexuals.

Hypothesis 3 (H3): Audiences' emotional responses to homosexuals influence their opinions on homosexuality.

H3a: Anger toward homosexuals has a negative effect on one's support for gay rights.

H3b: Sympathy for homosexuals has a positive effect on one's support for gay rights.

Mechanisms of value framing: Values, value-related belief importance, and opinions

As discussed earlier, media frames are composed of various elements such as values, attributions, and symbolic devices. Many studies have examined the mechanisms through which core values reflected in a media frame influence the audience's beliefs and opinions (Brewer, 2001, 2002, 2003; Brewer & Gross, 2005). Value framing refers to the process by which a media frame connects an issue to particular values and thus strengthens this link in the mind of the audience. As a result, the audience may accept the perspective indicated by the frame (Brewer, 2001, 2002, 2003).

A group of scholars has proposed the so-called 'framing-as-priming' mechanism, which facilitates the effects of value framing on the audience's opinions. According to this model, framing effects occur through the adjustment of the temporary accessibility of diverse considerations at the moment of a given judgment (Kinder & Sanders, 1996; Zaller & Feldman, 1992). That is, the values reflected in a particular media frame are made directly accessible in the mind of the audience and thus are used in decision-making, indicating that framing effects are mediated by the accessibility of value-related beliefs.

However, Nelson and his colleagues (1997, 1999) challenged this perspective, claiming that framing effects occur through a psychological process in which individuals are more likely to deliberate in their evaluation of the relative importance of different considerations that are activated by a frame. In other words, a conscious judgment about which considerations are more important and relevant to the issue at hand may induce different attitudes toward the issue (Hochschild, 1993). Harris and Mills (1985, p. 138) considered the decision-making process 'as a weighting process using conflicting values.' That is, not all accessible elements are employed at the moment of a particular judgment. Those beliefs that are perceived to be important by an individual are likely to play a crucial role in the formation of the individual's opinion. In sum, it is the perceived importance of value-related beliefs, not merely the accessibility of these beliefs, that mediates the relationship between value frames and opinions (Kristiansen & Zanna, 1994; Nelson & Oxley, 1999; Steenhaut & Kenhove, 2006).

For instance, Nelson et al. (1997) asked the participants to read one of two local news stories about a KKK (Ku Klux Klan) rally. One story emphasized the KKK's rights to freedom of speech, whereas the other highlighted a disturbance of public order during the rally. They exposed the participants to these news articles and then asked them to assess the perceived importance of various beliefs regarding civil liberties and public order when determining 'whether or not the KKK should be allowed to make speeches and hold demonstrations in public' (p. 571). They found that the participants exposed to the story emphasizing rights to freedom of speech rated beliefs about civil liberties to be more important and were more tolerant of the KKK, whereas those exposed to the other story emphasized beliefs about public order and were less tolerant. The results of this simple experiment clearly demonstrate that value frames in the media presentation of an issue can influence audiences' opinions by altering their perception of the importance of various value-related beliefs.

Most individuals possess conflicting beliefs about controversial social issues and are often 'unable to determine their relative importance' (Chong & Druckman, 2007, p. 105). By drawing on a particular set of values, media frames can function as an important cue by which audiences decide which beliefs are more or less important in the formation of their opinions on a given issue. Competing values reflected in gay-themed entertainment programs can be identified, but such values are not necessarily oppositional. Recent movies and television dramas have tended to highlight homosexuality or gay rights in a largely favorable light but in subtly different contexts in terms of values. For example, family values (as traditional moral values) have often been intertwined with anti-gay themes, whereas individualism has functioned mainly as a value system supporting gay rights (Brewer, 2003). However, recent movies such as *Beautiful Thing* and *Lan Yu* have used family values to support the pro-gay perspective. In particular, the pro-gay perspective can be better communicated to audiences in the context of a relatively conservative culture (e.g., China) when it is combined with more traditional values.

Based on the above discussion, this study investigates the mechanism of value framing by considering pro-gay programs with subtle differences in terms of their underlying values. More specifically, the study differentiates family values from individualistic ones to elaborate on the pro-gay perspective in entertainment media framing. Examining how different frames advocate a largely similar perspective on a controversial social issue, this study further compares the effectiveness of a frame reflecting family values with that indicating individualistic values in terms of their ability to indirectly influence the audience's support for gay rights in a conservative cultural context.

In this regard, we propose the following research question (RQ1): How do different types of value frames by gay-themed entertainment programs influence the audience's opinions on homosexuality and how does the perceived importance of value-related beliefs mediate this process? More specifically, which value frame (a frame reflecting family values vs. that reflecting individualistic values) is more effective in inducing the audience's support for gay rights in the context of a traditional culture?

Method

Experimental design and stimuli

To examine the effects of entertainment media framing and its mechanisms in terms of the controversial social issue of homosexuality, we conducted two separate experiments: Experiment 1 to address the mechanism of attribution framing (H1, H2, and H3) and Experiment 2 to address the mechanism of value framing (RQ1). To use actual movies and television dramas as experimental stimuli, we reviewed 20 entertainment programs with gay-related themes. We selected a total of four programs and edited each to prepare 35-minute-long video clips for each experimental condition.

Experimental design and stimuli in Experiment 1

We recruited a total of 100 students from various departments at a Chinese university for Experiment 1 and randomly assigned them to two experimental conditions.² Their participation was voluntary, and they received no compensation. The two groups were equivalent in terms of age ($t = -0.354$, ns), gender ($\chi^2 = 0.176$, ns), political ideology ($t = 0.103$, ns), and the number of homosexuals among significant others ($t = 0.416$, ns).

The participants in the ‘controllable’ condition ($N = 50$) watched a video clip from the Hong Kong movie *Peony Pavilion*, which features a love story about a Kun opera performer who marries a wealthy old man as his fifth wife in old China. She later falls in love with another woman who already has a young male lover. The two women become distraught and torn between the complicated relationships but ultimately choose each other as a lifetime partner. This movie ultimately defines homosexuality as a matter of individual free will. That is, it proposes that people choose their sexual identity and thus attributes the origin of homosexuality to controllable factors.

On the other hand, the participants in the ‘uncontrollable’ condition ($N = 49$) watched a video clip from the Hong Kong movie *Butterfly*, which narrates a lesbian love story in modern Hong Kong. The main character, a married woman, has tried to suppress her homosexuality since her school days. She encounters a young woman, falls in love with her, and goes through a process of self-realization, becoming aware that she cannot continue her marriage. In the end, she starts a new life with her female lover. This movie frames homosexuality as a genetic trait or a natural phenomenon and thus as uncontrollable, suggesting that people are born homosexual and thus cannot control their sexual orientation.

Experimental design and stimuli in Experiment 2

China is one of the largest entertainment media markets in Asia (and arguably in the world). Among many international entertainment programs shown in China (most of which have depicted more liberal lifestyles than their Chinese counterparts), those from Korea have been particularly popular. The term ‘Korean Wave’ (hallyu in Korean) exemplifies the huge popularity of Korean dramas, movies, music, and celebrities, among others. This phenomenon has attracted considerable attention from researchers in recent years (Dator & Seo, 2004; Shim, 2008), but few have

explored the effects of the Korean Wave from the perspective of framing theory. In this regard, we examined the framing effects of Korean entertainment programs on the participants' opinions on gay-related issues. Popular entertainment programs in Korea have increasingly adopted same-sex relationships as the main subject of a story (Lee, 2009). Therefore, Korean movies or dramas can be important outlets for the Chinese audience to get exposed to the issue of homosexuality, and, for this reason, we selected Korean programs as the treatment material.

We recruited additional 100 participants for Experiment 2 from various departments at the same university and randomly assigned them to two experimental groups.³ Again, participation was voluntary, and there was no compensation. The two groups were equivalent in terms of age ($t = -0.003$, ns), gender ($\chi^2 = 0.835$, ns), and the number of homosexuals among significant others ($t = -0.021$, ns) but not in terms of political ideology ($t = 4.216$, $p < 0.001$). To resolve this problem, we controlled for the effects of political ideology as well as other demographic and psychological variables on the dependent variables in the regression analyses of the effects of value framing.

The manipulation materials used in Experiment 2 differed in terms of their underlying core values: family values versus individualistic values.⁴ First, the participants in the frame condition reflecting family values ($N = 48$) watched a video clip from the Korean television drama *Life Is Beautiful*. The two main characters, both gay and born and raised in traditional families, encounter various emotional and family conflicts after declaring their sexual orientation. However, their families finally accept them as they are and acknowledge them as a couple. This drama emphasizes the importance of unconditional love and tolerance between family members. On the other hand, the participants in the frame condition reflecting individualistic values ($N = 49$) watched a video clip from the Korean movie *No Regret*, a love story about an upper-class young man and a male prostitute. Because of the difference in their socioeconomic status, they confront various barriers to their relationship but finally realize their love. This movie portrays homosexual romance as something equivalent to its heterosexual counterpart, and in doing so it highlights individuals' right to choose their own lifestyle and identity regardless of how different these may be from their society's mainstream ideas. To help the participants follow the plots of these Korean programs, we included subtitles in the treatment video clips.

Measurement of key dependent variables

Perceived controllability

We operationalized perceived controllability as one's attributional belief that homosexuality is caused by some controllable (i.e., nonhereditary) factors and measured it by asking the participants to indicate the extent to which they agreed or disagreed with six belief statements adapted from the attribution-style measures developed by Wood and Bartowski (2004): 'Homosexuals are born with their sexual orientation,' 'Homosexuality is due to biology and genetics,' 'Homosexuality is unchangeable,' 'One's sexual orientation is controllable,' 'Homosexuality is a lifestyle choice,' and 'Homosexuality is due to learning and preferences, not to biology and genetics.' The results of an exploratory factor analysis (EFA) (a principal component

analysis with Varimax rotation) indicate that all six items loaded on a single factor, explaining 72.51% of the total variance. The last three items attributed homosexuality to behavioral or environmental factors, whereas the first three, to hereditary factors. Therefore, we reverse-coded the first three items. We averaged these items to create an index of the perceived controllability of homosexuality (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.922$, $M = 3.31$, $SD = 1.12$).

Emotions

We allowed the participants in each experimental condition to watch the video clip and then asked them to indicate the extent to which they felt anger toward or sympathy for gay people in general. We measured their anger by using the following item: 'How often do you feel anger toward gay people?' ($M = 2.52$, $SD = 1.29$). We measured sympathy by using the following item: 'How often do you feel pity for gay people?' ($M = 2.68$, $SD = 1.10$).

The perceived importance of value-related reliefs

After viewing the stimulus material, the participants indicated the extent to which they perceived the importance of 10 belief statements in the formation of their opinions on homosexuality. We adapted these items from the family support scale in Rose (1990) and from scales of individualism in several previous studies (Han & Shavitt, 1993; Oyserman, Coon, & Kimmelmeier, 2002). The EFA results indicate that these 10 items loaded on two factors, explaining 75.06% of the total variance. The first five items proposed the idea that family members should support, understand, accept, protect, and respect homosexual family members. We averaged these items to create an index of the perceived importance of beliefs about family values (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.946$, $M = 3.23$, $SD = 1.27$). The remaining five items emphasized that all individuals, including homosexuals, should be given equal rights to choose their own lifestyle and pursue their own desires. We averaged these items to create an index of the perceived importance of beliefs about individualistic values (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.842$, $M = 2.93$, $SD = 1.02$).

Opinions on homosexuality

We employed the participants' opinions on gay-related issues as the ultimate dependent variable for each type of media framing. We asked the participants to indicate the extent to which they agreed or disagreed with a total of nine statements about homosexuality/homosexuals. For this, we employed the SLGHR (Support for Lesbian and Gay Human Rights) and ATLG (Attitudes toward Lesbians and Gay Men) scales in Ellis, Kitlinger, and Wilkinson (2002), who used them to examine same-sex relationships. The EFA results indicate that these items loaded on two factors, explaining 57.71% of the total variance. The first four items advocated gay people's equal rights to jobs, housing, freedom of expression, favorable workplace conditions, and protection from discrimination. We averaged these items to create an index of social support for gay rights (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.687$, $M = 3.10$, $SD = 0.77$). The remaining five items proposed that gay people's personal dignity and preferences should be respected and emphasized homosexuality as an acceptable expression of

sexuality. We averaged these items to create an index of personal support for gay rights (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.819$, $M = 3.38$, $SD = 0.92$).

We considered a few variables that may influence individuals' opinions on the issue of homosexuality, including gender (female, 60.7%), political ideology (1 = very liberal, 7 = very conservative, $M = 3.53$, $SD = 1.40$), and the number of homosexuals among family members, relatives, close friends, and acquaintances ($M = 0.06$, $SD = 0.23$), for control purposes. In addition, we considered narrative involvement for control purposes and measured it with a total of three items that asked the participants to indicate the extent to which they were interested in the story or attracted to the characters. All three items loaded on a single factor, explaining 57.07% of the total variance (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.624$, $M = 3.08$, $SD = 0.96$). Unless otherwise specified, we measured all items on a five-point Likert-type scale (Table 1).

Results

We assessed the effects of fictional entertainment programs depicting gay-related issues on the participants' opinions on homosexuality by examining their causal attributions, emotions, and perception of the importance of value-related beliefs. For this, we conducted multiple regression analyses and thus reconstructed the variables for the experimental stimuli as dummy variables. In Experiment 1, we coded the 'controllable' frame as 1 and the 'uncontrollable' frame as 0. In Experiment 2, we coded the 'family values' frame as 1 and the 'individualistic values' frame as 0. The results indicate that multicollinearity was not a serious problem in any regression analysis.

Effects of attribution framing on perceived controllability, emotions, and opinions

H1 predicted that fictional entertainment media's attribution frames in terms of controllability would influence the participants' perception of the controllability of

Table 1. Descriptive statistics by frame type.

Dependent variables	Experiment 1		Experiment 2	
	Controllable ($N = 50$)	Uncontrollable ($N = 49$)	Family values (FV, $N = 48$)	Individualistic values (IV, $N = 49$)
Perceived controllability	4.31 ^a (0.37)	2.30 ^b (0.56)		
Anger	3.26 ^a (0.90)	2.07 ^b (0.91)		
Sympathy	2.29 ^a (0.75)	2.87 ^b (0.83)		
FV-related belief importance			4.12 ^a (0.82)	2.39 ^b (1.00)
IV-related belief importance			2.68 ^a (0.91)	3.17 ^b (1.08)
Personal support for gay rights	2.54 ^a (0.83)	3.64 ^b (0.60)	3.95 ^a (0.74)	3.40 ^b (0.84)
Social support for gay rights	3.03 ^a (0.77)	3.22 ^a (0.60)	3.36 ^a (0.78)	2.76 ^b (0.79)

Note: Entries are means with standard deviations in parentheses. Different superscripts mean a statistically significant difference between two frame types at $p < 0.05$.

Table 2. OLS (Ordinary Least Squares) regression analysis: effects of attribution frames on perceived controllability and emotions.

	Causal attribution	Emotions	
Independent variables	Perceived controllability	Anger toward homosexuals	Sympathy for homosexuals
<i>Block 1: Control variables</i>			
Gender (female = 1)	−0.024	−0.048	−0.087
Conservative ideology	0.066	0.046	−0.044
No. of homosexuals among significant others	0.027	−0.241**	0.060
Narrative involvement	−0.035	0.030	0.082
R^2 (%)	4.9	10.6*	1.5
<i>Block 2: Media frames</i>			
Attribution frames (Controllable = 1)	0.917***	0.593***	−0.082
Inc. R^2 (%)	78.0***	28.3***	11.4**
<i>Block 3: Causal attribution</i>			
Perceived controllability		−0.044	−0.293
Inc. R^2 (%)		0.0	1.5
Total R^2 (%)	82.9	38.9	14.4

Note: Entries are standardized beta coefficients from final regression equation with all blocks of variables in the model. $N=99$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

homosexuality. The results in Table 2 provide strong support for H1 ($\beta = 0.917$, $p < 0.001$). Specifically, the participants who were exposed to a movie framing homosexuality as a matter of an individual's personal choice (i.e., as something controllable) were less likely to attribute homosexuality to genetic factors than those exposed to a movie framing homosexuality as a hereditary trait (i.e., as something uncontrollable).

H2 posited that the participants' perception of the controllability of homosexuality would influence their emotional responses to homosexuals. More specifically, H2a predicted that the participants perceiving a higher degree of controllability would be more likely to feel anger toward homosexuals, whereas H2b predicted a negative effect of perceived controllability on sympathy. However, the results in Table 2 provide no support for both these hypotheses. Perceived controllability had no significant effect on anger ($\beta = -0.044$, ns) or sympathy ($\beta = -0.293$, ns). Instead, exposure to the frame portraying homosexuality as controllable had a direct positive effect on anger ($\beta = 0.593$, $p < 0.01$). That is, the participants who watched a movie framing homosexuality as something controllable were more likely to feel anger toward homosexuals than those exposed to a program framing homosexuality as a hereditary trait.

H3 predicted that the participants' emotional responses to homosexuals would influence their opinions on gay rights. Specifically, H3a concerned the effects of anger on these opinions, whereas H3b, those of sympathy. As discussed earlier, a factor analysis identified two meaningful dimensions of the dependent variable opinions on homosexuality: personal and social support for gay rights. The results in Table 3 provide support for H3a and H3b only in terms of personal support for gay rights. That is, anger toward homosexuals had a significant negative effect on

Table 3. OLS regression analysis: effects of attribution frames on opinions

Independent variables	Opinions	
	Personal support for gay rights	Social support for gay rights
<i>Block 1: Control variables</i>		
Gender (female = 1)	0.014	0.047
Conservative ideology	-0.289***	-0.010
No. of homosexuals	0.229**	0.214*
Narrative involvement	0.062	0.152
R ² (%)	22.3***	8.5 [†]
<i>Block 2: Media frames</i>		
Attribution frames (Controllable = 1)	-0.257	-0.105
Inc. R ² (%)	35.9***	2.5
<i>Block 3: Causal attribution</i>		
Perceived controllability	-0.209	-0.002
Inc. R ² (%)	1.0	0.0
<i>Block 4: Emotions</i>		
Anger	-0.223**	-0.152
Sympathy	0.144*	-0.080
Inc. R ² (%)	6.3***	1.4
Total R ² (%)	65.6	12.4

Note: Entries are standardized beta coefficients from final regression equation with all blocks of variables in the model. $N=99$, [†] $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

personal support for gay rights ($\beta = -0.223$, $p < 0.01$), whereas sympathy had a positive effect ($\beta = 0.144$, $p < 0.05$). This implies that feeling pity for homosexuals encouraged the participants to endorse gay people's personal dignity.

Overall, perceived controllability had no significant mediating effect on the relationship between exposure to media frames and emotions (and thus opinions). However, anger played a significant mediating role in the relationship between attribution frames and opinions on same-sex relationships. That is, the participants who were exposed to an entertainment program framing homosexuality as a matter of an individual's personal choice were likely to feel anger toward homosexuals, which in turn reduced their support for gay rights.

These results indicate that entertainment media's attribution frames were more likely to influence the participants' opinions at the personal level than at the social level. This suggests that, although an individual may be willing to accept homosexuals as an integral part of society and may attempt to respect their personal dignity, he or she may still reject their equal rights to various social systems.

Effects of value framing on the perceived importance of value-related beliefs and opinions

RQ1 addressed how different types of value frames would influence the participants' opinions on homosexuality and whether their perception of the importance of value-related beliefs would mediate this process. Because the frame reflecting family values and that reflecting individualistic values both implicitly advocated a pro-gay

Table 4. OLS regression analysis: effects of value frames on the perceived importance of value-related beliefs and opinions.

Independent variables	Belief Importance		Opinions	
	FV-related belief importance	IV-related belief importance	Personal support for gay rights	Social support for gay rights
<i>Block 1: Controls</i>				
Gender	0.033	0.092	−0.024	−0.041
Conservative ideology	−0.104	−0.062	−0.131	−0.423***
No. of homosexuals	0.140 [†]	0.047	0.147 [†]	−0.006
Narrative involvement	0.102	0.428***	0.290**	0.034
<i>R</i> ² (%)	25.2***	11.1*	32.7***	33.0***
<i>Block 2: Media frames</i>				
Value frames (FV = 1)	0.614***	−0.438***	−0.062	−0.010
Inc. <i>R</i> ² (%)	27.3***	13.9***	0.8	0.8
<i>Block 3: Belief importance</i>				
FV-related belief importance			0.376**	0.307*
IV-related belief importance			0.151	0.176 [†]
Inc. <i>R</i> ² (%)			9.7**	8.0**
Total <i>R</i> ² (%)	52.6	25.0	43.2	41.8

Note: Entries are standardized beta coefficients from final regression equation with all blocks of variables in the model. *N* = 97, [†]*p* < 0.10, **p* < 0.05, ***p* < 0.01, ****p* < 0.001.

perspective, we examined whether the former would be more effective than the latter in terms of their indirect effects on the participants' support for gay rights through the perceived importance of value-related beliefs.

As shown in Table 4, value frames had an indirect positive effect on the participants' support for gay rights. That is, the participants exposed to the frame reflecting family values were significantly more likely to emphasize the importance of beliefs about family values ($\beta = 0.614$, $p < 0.001$) than those exposed to the frame reflecting individualistic values, and the perceived importance of these beliefs had a significant positive effect on personal ($\beta = 0.376$, $p < 0.01$) as well as social ($\beta = 0.307$, $p < 0.05$) support for gay rights. In other words, the perceived importance of beliefs about family values had a significant mediating effect on the relationship between exposure to the frame reflecting family values and opinions.

Although the participants exposed to an entertainment program focusing on individualistic values were more likely to emphasize individualistic beliefs ($\beta = -0.438$, $p < 0.001$), the perceived importance of those beliefs had no significant effect on personal support ($\beta = 0.151$, ns) and only marginal effects on social support ($\beta = 0.176$, $p < 0.10$) for gay rights. This implies that the perceived importance of beliefs about individualistic values was not a significant mediator of the relationship between exposure to the 'individualistic values' frame and opinions. Overall, in the

communication of a pro-gay perspective, the frame reflecting family values was more effective than that reflecting individualistic ones. That is, the former was more likely to successfully influence the participants' support for gay rights by influencing their perception of the importance of value-related beliefs.

Discussion

In this study, we investigated the framing effects of entertainment programs dealing with a controversial social issue (homosexuality) and examined the mechanisms underlying these effects. In particular, we focused on the diverse ways in which movies and television dramas frame homosexuality in terms of attributions and core values. Based on an extensive literature review, we considered the following two mechanisms underlying framing effects: one concerning attribution framing and the other, value framing.

In terms of the effects of attribution framing, we focused on controllability. More specifically, we hypothesized that entertainment media's framing of the origin of homosexuality would influence the participants' perception of the controllability of homosexuality and that this would then lead to the arousal of anger or sympathy. We further hypothesized that anger or sympathy would then influence the participants' opinions on homosexuality. The results indicate that the participants' exposure to attribution frames had a significant effect on their controllability judgment but no significant effect on their emotional responses to homosexuals. However, anger had a significant mediating effect on the relationship between controllability frames and opinions. More specifically, the participants exposed to an entertainment program framing homosexuality as something controllable through the individual's free will were more likely to feel anger, and this significantly limited their support for gay people's personal dignity and equal rights to jobs, housing, and freedom of expression, among others.

In terms of the effects of value framing, we explored whether gay-related values reflected in a fictional entertainment program would influence the participants' opinions by changing their perception of the importance of value-related beliefs. For this, we considered two types of values in media frames implicitly advocating a pro-gay perspective: family values and individualistic ones. Specifically, we examined whether traditional values would be more effective in influencing the participants' opinions on the issue of homosexuality in the context of a conservative culture. According to the results, the frame reflecting family values was more likely to increase personal as well as social support for gay rights indirectly through the perceived importance of value-related beliefs, than the media frame highlighting the value of individuality in sexual orientation.

These findings have important implications for research on entertainment media framing. The two main mechanisms underlying framing effects – the path from attribution (controllability) frames to emotions to opinions and that from value frames to the perceived importance of value-related beliefs to opinions – can be applied to other controversial social issues. For example, entertainment programs related to the issue of abortion may influence the audience's support for relevant policy initiatives by adopting a particular value frame such as 'freedom to determine one's own life' and 'responsibility for others' (Harris & Mills, 1985). Movies or television dramas dealing with the issue of capital punishment may also influence the

audience's opinions by attributing heinous crimes to causes such as social conditions or individual misconduct (Mooney & Lee, 2000). In terms of the issue of poverty, entertainment programs can influence the audience's support for welfare policies by emphasizing specific sets of values that are associated with that issue (e.g., social responsibility vs. individual responsibility) and/or by portraying the problem as either controllable or uncontrollable (Hunt, 1996).

In addition, unlike in some previous studies (Greitemeyer & Rudolph, 2003; Harder-Markel & Joslyn, 2008; Weiner, 2006), perceived controllability did not mediate the effects of exposure to attribution frames on the participants' emotions. Unlike news programs, entertainment programs are more likely to elicit affective responses than cognitive reasoning from the audience (Kim & Vishak, 2008). That is, emotional arousal may precede cognitive judgments about responsibility or causation, which may explain why the participants' inferences about the controllability of homosexuality had no effect on their emotions. Instead, exposure to a movie connoting a certain attribution frame directly elicited a particular emotion from the participants. This suggests that the mechanism of attribution framing hypothesized in the present study as well as those in previous studies should be modified based on the unique nature of a given media genre.

Previous studies examining value framing in the context of homosexuality have generally compared equality and morality frames in terms of their effects on support for gay rights (Brewer, 2003; Lewis & Rogers, 1999; Wilcox & Wolpert, 2000). However, the present study's results suggest that in actual movies and television dramas, traditional family values such as unconditional love and trust may be associated with the pro-gay perspective. Individualism, which emphasizes individuals' right to choose their own lifestyle (including sexuality and behavior), is also closely associated with the pro-gay perspective. This suggests that it would be both important and useful to explore how largely similar perspectives on a controversial social issue can be contextualized in terms of various core values. The effects of value framing may vary according to a particular set of values underlying the narrative. In this study, the frame reflecting family values was more effective in forming the participants' opinions than that reflecting individualistic values. This result may be due to the cultural context of China. In China, collectivism remains a dominant part of cultural values. In this context, family values are more likely than individualistic ones to resonate with the existing value system among the general public. As Gamson and Modigliani (1989) suggested, a frame that resonates with the surrounding culture may better facilitate the audience's formation of opinions on a controversial social issue. Shim (2006) pointed out that the growing popularity of Korean popular culture in China as well as in other Asian countries may be partially due to its 'cultural proximity.' In other words, Korean television dramas and films successfully echo Asian sentiments such as family values, and this explains why they have rapidly and steadily attracted huge audiences in China.

This study contributes to the framing literature by examining the mechanism underlying entertainment media framing and its effects but has several limitations. First and most importantly, internal validity may be an issue. We used video clips edited from actual movies and television dramas as the experimental stimuli, and therefore the stimuli used in the experiments were somewhat different from each other in terms of their characterization, plot, and aesthetics, among others. In this

regard, some factors other than the variables of interest (i.e., attribution patterns or core values) might have been responsible for some portions of the variance in the criterion variables. In particular, some of the observed effects might have been due not to the variation in the independent variables but to differences in the experimental stimuli in terms of program quality (Slater et al., 2006). That is, the participants might have paid more attention to those programs that were of higher quality in terms of the narrative structure and visuals. We were particularly concerned about this possibility since the two groups in Experiment 1 were significantly different from each other in terms of narrative involvement ($t = -2.644$, $p < 0.05$) and so were those two in Experiment 2 ($t = -4.251$, $p < 0.001$). To address this problem, we controlled for the effects of narrative involvement in all regression analyses and found largely similar results. According to these analyses, the observed effects on the dependent variables can be clearly attributed to the manipulation of the independent variables. However, we should have conducted a pretest or a manipulation check to better ensure that the experiments were internally valid.

Second, the two groups in Experiment 1 were equivalent in that there were no statistical differences in terms of age, gender, political ideology, and the number of homosexuals among significant others. However, the two treatment groups in Experiment 2 showed a meaningful difference in terms of political ideology. To address this problem, we controlled for political ideology as well as other demographic variables in all regression analyses.

Third, the experiments were limited in that they had only treatment groups. If we had considered a control group that viewed nothing or a video clip showing a totally irrelevant program, then we could have provided a more comprehensive understanding of the effects of attribution and value framing. We note the relatively small number of participants in each experimental group as another limitation.

Finally, it must be noted that we employed only one entertainment program for each condition and thus that the observed effects may be limited to the specific programs used. In this regard, future research should employ more sophisticated methods (e.g., the use of special experimental designs and/or a pool of similar stimuli) to achieve greater internal and external validity. In addition, future research should consider a wider range of media frame components, including diverse symbolic devices and visual images (Coleman, 2010). Rhode and Hamilton (2006) highlighted a need for identifying those elements of fictional dramas that are most likely to induce attributional thinking and suggested characters, plots, and perspectives, among others, as such elements. By exploring such diverse components and their effects, future research can provide a better understanding of the complicated and multifaceted nature of entertainment media framing.

Notes

1. Another media outlet estimated this number to be approximately 40–50 million (3–4% of China's total population) (Women of China, July 29, 2011).
2. We excluded one participant from the analysis because of his previous exposure to the manipulation material.
3. We excluded from the analysis a total of three participants who answered that they had watched the given movie or drama.

4. We carefully reviewed various gay-themed Korean movies and dramas to select those two which were clearly different from each other in terms of the underlying values (that is, family values versus individualistic values).

Notes on contributors

Lihong Zhang received her master's degree in Journalism and Mass Communication from Korea University, Seoul, Republic of Korea. This manuscript is partly based upon her thesis.

Young Min is an associate professor in the School of Media & Communication at Korea University. Her research focuses on media effects on public opinion and behavior in various political contexts.

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